



Globally networked: Intraorganizational boundary spanning in the global organization

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ABSTRACT

Multinational corporations (MNCs) need to sense, source, and mobilize knowledge when and where it arises, whether at home, or elsewhere in the world. For this reason, MNCs benefit from employee networks of relationships that span across intraorganizational barriers, allowing for the efficient mobilization of knowledge across boundaries. Yet, which organizational members are more likely to be able to develop these boundary spanning networks? We leverage a unique data set from a large multinational corporation to empirically test a comprehensive model that captures the effect of an employee's mandate, expertise, and behavioral orientations on her likelihood to span intraorganizational boundaries that manifest themselves in the form of hierarchies, intra-functional domains, and geographic territories. We find that the employees that are more likely to be boundary spanners are those having mandates with a global impact, high levels of expertise, and a collaborative orientation in their networking behaviors. In addition, we find that these effects are stronger for those employees that have large formal workflow networks.

1. Introduction

In the International Business (IB) literature it has been highlighted that MNCs' competitive *raison d'être* is cross-border knowledge creation, as well as transfer, and exploitation (Doz, Santos, & Williamson, 2001; Kogut & Zander, 1993). As the pace of technological change has accelerated, MNCs no longer have the luxury of simply cultivating home-grown responses to innovations by rivals. Staying abreast of requirements for continuous developments and innovations entails MNCs to sense, source, and mobilize new knowledge streams when and where they arise, whether at home or elsewhere in the world. Recognizing this aspect, IB scholars devoted considerable attention to the study of intraorganizational knowledge mobilization (Gupta & Govindarajan, 2000; Minbaeva, Pedersen, Björkman, Fey, & Park, 2003; Monteiro, Arvidsson, & Birkinshaw, 2008).

While most IB studies have focused on the organizational level, more recently, several scholars have argued for a focus on people, stressing the importance of exploring the micro-foundations of knowledge mobilization between the employees of MNCs (Foss, Husted, & Michailova, 2010; Foss & Pedersen, 2004; Haas & Cummings, 2014). The intuition behind this perspective is that it is not organizations, but

the individual employees that tap into, and make use of knowledge for the benefit of organizations. Thus, individual employees are the key players building those informal and emergent networks that lubricate and complement the formal organizational processes and structures designed to guide decision making and knowledge mobilization (McEvily, Soda, & Tortoriello, 2014).

MNCs bring together individuals with very different profiles, from distant parts of the world, and of the organization (Earley & Gibson, 2002), thus offering a good platform for the formation of boundary spanning relations (Schotter, Mudambi, Doz, & Gaur, 2017). Previous research has devoted particular attention to three types of boundaries arising from the activities carried out in MNCs. Geographical boundaries, such as working in different countries, world regions, or international time zones (Cramton, 2001; Espinosa, Cummings, Wilson, & Pearce, 2003; Hinds & Mortensen, 2005). Structural boundaries, such as working in different functions or functional areas, divisions, or business units (Bartlett, Ghoshal, & Birkinshaw, 2003; Dasí, Pedersen, Gooderham, Elter, & Hildrum, 2017; Puranam, Raveendran, & Knudsen, 2012). Hierarchical boundaries, arising from differences in tenure, or formal levels in the organizational hierarchy (Reagans, Zuckerman, & McEvily, 2004; Zenger & Lawrence, 1989).

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